

India's first and only unmanned aircraft manufacturing hub. Since TESCOM manages our supply chain and has demonstrated specialised knowledge for innovation in every aspect of manufacturing and they have been a part of our journey, we have never felt the need to partner with other manufacturers.

Q. What unique advantage can TESCOM offer its customers through partnership?

Our integrated manufacturing facility ensures the lowest cost, matching or surpassing Chinese prices. Swift delivery is a priority, and transparency in operations fosters customer loyalty. We prioritise partnerships aligned with shared goals, offering cost, quality, and innovation advantages through controlled supply chains.

In the dynamic landscape of rapid innovation, our intent is to create a competitive advantage for customers. Collaborative partnerships enable us to understand market requirements, ensuring a continuous supply chain while fostering innovation. Through strategic alliances, we transform into valued business partners, translating benefits for customers. Our centralised manufacturing, coupled with planned automation, guarantees the highest quality and efficiency.

Q. Will such a partnership enable TESCOM to attract more drone customers, or will it act as a deterrent?

Partnering with customers will allow us to anticipate what our customers need and, in turn, understand what the market needs. We can be more engaged with the customer and build loyalty and trust as we will take ownership of the business by understanding end customer and market needs. With the current plan and strategy, since we will always be market-ready, we may attract more customers. As contract manufacturers, we always maintain the confidentiality of our customers, so handling multiple customers from the same vertical will not be a challenge. We plan to have separate manufacturing blocks in our drone park where each customer's design will be taken for manufacturing. This will ensure total confidentiality.

Q. Why should drone OEMs look at outsourcing their manufacturing to TESCOM and not setting up their plant?

TESCOM offers drone OEMs valuable partnerships, ensuring agility, responsiveness, and economies of scale to meet sudden demand surges. Outsourcing to TESCOM alleviates concerns about the fragile global supply chain affected by geopolitical changes. Plans for a 15-acre drone park, with strategic partners for key components, ensure a hurdle-free supply chain. TESCOM's horizontal integration aims to address challenges, positioning it as a leading player in drone manufacturing. Though not fully mature, drone technology and demand benefit from TESCOM's large-scale horizontal integration, providing early access to solutions. The seamless ecosystem created by TESCOM will make its offerings attractive for the OEMs.

Q. Is TESCOM ready to work with startups that initially deal in very low quantities of drones, or are you aiming for the major players?

TESCOM will support startups by offering alignment, assistance, and long-term guidance. Our objective is to become the preferred white-label manufacturer for major OEMs, ensuring controlled processes and quality systems. We aim to surpass Chinese prices and supply chain efficiency by catering to small and large companies. Our ultimate goal is customisation and white labelling, with a commitment to confidentiality through unique designs for each customer.

Q. How does TESCOM view various initiatives and policies by the government of India (and some state governments) to drive demand for drones in India?

India has implemented leading regulations and policies addressing drone industry demand and supply through PLI and import bans. The global market is expected to follow suit, fostering rapid growth. The Drone Rules 2021 is a pivotal change for India's drone industry. Central government subsidies include the NAMO Drone Didi Scheme (80% subsidy up to 8 lakhs), FPO Kisan Drone Subsidy

(75% subsidy), and Individual Kisan Drone (50% subsidy up to 5 lakhs). Government initiatives like Vikas Bharat Sankalp Yatra raise awareness. IFFCO procured 2500 drones this year, planning to support agriculturists more. Collaboration among ministries and departments addresses industry challenges, supporting startups and large companies for ecosystem development. Schemes for women and self-help groups highlight the inclusion of women pilots in India's growing drone sector.

Q. What is your vision for TESCOM regarding drone manufacturing in India?

TESCOM aims to be India's drone manufacturer, and our vision is aligned with the Indian government's vision to turn India into a global drone hub. We intend to lead India's drone manufacturing aspirations by becoming India's premier drone destination. We want to lead the manufacturing of a seamless supply of all types of drones from all sectors and all categories. Our team headed by our Director Nandini is working on this at various levels and consolidating all the available resources in India.

Q. What challenges does TESCOM see in achieving this vision, and how do you plan to overcome them?

The communication gap between lawmakers and drone makers will be a challenge. Also, slow technology adoption due to a lack of awareness will delay the industry's growth. The fear of losing jobs in the ground-level workforce in the agricultural sector will also be challenging. Issues may arise in getting permission for drone flights, and overseas demonstration of drone technology will be challenging. Without export, we cannot lead in the sector, so regulatory bodies need to help us in easing out export norms for drones.

Discussions with central and state government departments are underway, and we are collectively expressing our concerns. We see that the support we are getting from the government machinery is phenomenal, and all these concerns and challenges will be addressed as the goal and vision of India is to become the "drone capital of the world." ■